FREE PLAYBOOK · EMAIL MARKETING

The Small Business Newsletter Playbook

How to build an email list the right way, welcome new subscribers properly, and send a monthly email people look forward to, in about an hour a month.

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bemoreswan.com
Written for owners who keep meaning to send one.

1 · WHY BOTHER

Why email still matters

Social media is rented space: the platform decides who sees your post. Your email list is yours. Every person on it asked to hear from you, and your email lands in their inbox, not in a feed.

You own it

If a platform changes its rules or your account is locked, your list is still there.

It reaches people

An email goes to every subscriber, not to whichever slice an algorithm picks.

It sells politely

People who signed up expect to hear about what you do. A monthly email keeps you in mind for when they need you.

The catch is that most small businesses start a newsletter, send three, and stop. Not for lack of ideas, but because every issue starts from scratch. This playbook gives you a list that grows on its own, a welcome that does the selling, and a recipe that turns each month's issue into an hour's work.

2 · YOUR LIST

Building your list, the right way

In the UK, marketing email to individuals needs their permission. That sounds like a hurdle, but it's really an advantage: a list of people who chose to hear from you is worth far more than a big list who didn't. This is a plain-English summary, not legal advice; the ICO's guidance at **ico.org.uk** has the detail.

Consent

People tick a box or fill in a form to say yes. The box must not be pre-ticked, and the wording must say what they'll get ("a monthly email with tips and offers").

The "soft opt-in"

Existing customers can get emails about similar products and services without ticking a box, if you offered them a clear way to opt out when you took their details, and in every email since.

- [ ] Never add people from a bought list, a business-card bowl or your contacts book without asking.
- [ ] Keep a record of when and how each person signed up.
- [ ] Put a working unsubscribe link in every email, make it one click, and honour it straight away.
- [ ] Ask for as little as you need: an email address and a first name is plenty.

Where sign-ups come from

A list grows when signing up is easy and offered in the places people already meet you.

Place	How
Your website	A short form on the home page and at the end of every article: one line saying what they get, an email box, a button.
Checkout and booking	An unticked box: "Send me the monthly email with tips and offers."
Social profiles	A link to a sign-up page in your bio, and an occasional post about what subscribers get.
In person	A QR code by the till, on receipts or on your business card that goes straight to the form.
Your email signature	One line with a link: "Get our free checklist and monthly tips."

3 · THE OFFER

A reason to sign up

"Sign up to our newsletter" gives people nothing to say yes to. Offer something they can have today, a **free gift**, and the newsletter becomes a bonus rather than the price.

Good free gifts

- A one-page checklist
- A short how-to guide
- A template or planner
- A seasonal guide ("What to plant in March")
- A first-visit or first-order offer, if you have one

What makes it work

- It solves one specific problem
- It's quick to use: minutes, not hours
- The title names the result
- It shows you know your stuff
- It leads naturally to what you sell

SEND IT BY EMAIL, STRAIGHT AWAY

Deliver the gift in the first email, not on a thank-you page. It proves the address is real, it teaches people your emails are worth opening, and it starts your welcome sequence on a high.

4 · WELCOME

The welcome sequence: three emails

Someone who has just signed up is more interested in you than they will ever be again. Three short emails in the first week turn that interest into trust, and do your selling for you, automatically, for every new subscriber. (The examples are for Juniper & Co, an imaginary florist.)

Email 1 · Straight away · Subject: Here's your flower care guide

Deliver the gift, say thank you, and set expectations: what you'll send and how often. Two short paragraphs and the download link. Sign it with your real name.

Job: keep the promise. Nothing to sell yet.

Email 2 · Day 3 · Subject: Why we started Juniper & Co

Your story, briefly: why you started, what you care about, and what makes you different. One photo of you or your place. Invite a reply: "What brought you here?"

Job: become a person, not a logo. Replies here are gold, so answer every one.

Email 3 · Day 7 · Subject: The thing most people ask us first

Your most useful piece of help, answering the question customers ask most, followed by one clear, honest next step: your most popular product, a booking link, or your introductory offer, stated exactly.

Job: help, then ask once. After this they join your regular monthly email.

Set it up once. Most email tools let you send a sequence automatically after someone signs up. Write these three on a quiet afternoon and they work for every subscriber you ever get. Re-read them once a year.

5 · EVERY MONTH

The monthly newsletter recipe

Same four ingredients every month, so you never start from a blank page. Aim for 200 to 400 words: something people can read with a cup of tea.

1. **One useful thing** (about half the email). A tip, a how-to, an answer to a question you were asked this month. This is why people open.
2. **One story** (a short paragraph). Something that happened: a customer, a job, a mistake, a small win. This is why people feel they know you.
3. **One piece of news** (a line or two). New product, new hours, a local event, a team member.
4. **One clear ask** (a line and a button). Book, buy, reply, forward to a friend. Only one, and say exactly what happens next.

Write it like a letter

"Hi Sarah," and then talk to one person. Short paragraphs. No jargon. Sign off with your name, not "The Team".

Keep the design plain

One column, one or two real photos, one button. Plain emails look personal and read well on a phone, where most people will open it.

The one-hour routine

Time	What you do
10 minutes	Pick this month's useful thing and story from your idea list (keep one on your phone all month).
30 minutes	Write it all in one go, top to bottom. Don't edit as you write.
10 minutes	Cut it by a fifth. Check every price, date and link. Add a photo.
10 minutes	Write the subject line and preview text, send yourself a test, read it on your phone, and schedule it.

Subject lines and preview text

In the inbox, people see three things: your name, the subject line and the preview text (the first line or so). Write all three on purpose.

Subject lines that work

- Name the useful thing: "How to keep tulips standing up"
- Be specific: "Our new Saturday hours (and a thank-you)"
- Ask a real question: "Are you planting too early?"
- Keep it short: most phones show about 40 characters

Avoid

- "Newsletter #14" (it says nothing)
- ALL CAPS and !!!
- Fake urgency or "Re:" on a newsletter
- Promising something the email doesn't deliver

Preview text is a second subject line. Use it to add to the first, not repeat it. *Subject: "How to keep tulips standing up." Preview: "Plus a wedding we'll never forget."*

Your "from" name

People decide whether to open partly on who it's from. A person beats a company: **"Sarah at Juniper & Co"** reads like a letter, while "Juniper & Co Newsletter" reads like marketing. Pick one and never change it, so people recognise you in their inbox.

Before you press Send

- [ ] Send a test to yourself and read it on your phone.
- [ ] Click every link and the button.
- [ ] Check names, prices and dates one last time.
- [ ] Read the subject line and preview text together, as they'll appear.

Draft your next three subject lines

7 · IDEAS

Twelve months of ideas

A year of starting points. Swap in what's true for your business and your customers' seasons; a wedding florist's busy months aren't an accountant's.

Month	Useful thing	Story or news
January	A fresh-start checklist for your customers	What you're changing this year
February	The question you're asked most, answered properly	A favourite customer story
March	Spring prep: what to do now	Behind the scenes of a busy week
April	A myth in your industry, busted	Something new you're trying
May	A short how-to with photos	Meet the team (or you)
June	Before and after: one job in detail	A local event you're part of
July	A quick summer guide	A mistake and what you learned
August	Your favourite tools or suppliers, and why	A quiet-month project
September	Back-to-routine tips	What customers asked for this year
October	Planning ahead for the busy season	A new product or service
November	A gift or ordering guide, with dates	How to get the most from you at Christmas
December	Your year in five lessons	Thank you, and your holiday hours

NEVER RUN OUT

Every time a customer asks you something, add it to your idea note. Twelve good questions is a year of newsletters, and the answers are things you already know.

8 · MEASURE

What to measure (and what to ignore)

Open rates used to be the headline number. They're far less reliable now: privacy features in several email apps, Apple Mail especially, register an "open" whether or not anyone read the email. Look at these instead.

Clicks

How many people clicked something. The clearest sign that an email was read and was useful.

Replies

The best sign of all. Ask a question in every email and answer every reply.

Unsubscribes

A few each month is normal and healthy. A spike after one email tells you what not to repeat.

Sales and bookings

Did the ask work? Use a link or code that's only in the email, or simply ask new customers where they heard about you.

KEEP YOUR LIST CLEAN

Every few months, remove addresses that bounce, and send people who haven't clicked anything in a year a short "Still want these?" email. A smaller list that wants your emails reaches more inboxes than a big one that doesn't.

9 · CHECKLIST

Your checklist

Once

- [ ] A sign-up form on my website, with an unticked box and clear wording about what people get.
- [ ] A free gift that solves one problem, delivered in the first email.
- [ ] A three-email welcome sequence, sent automatically.
- [ ] A note on my phone for newsletter ideas.

Every month

- [ ] One useful thing, one story, one piece of news, one clear ask.
- [ ] 200 to 400 words, written like a letter, signed with my name.
- [ ] A subject line that names the useful thing, plus preview text that adds to it.
- [ ] Every price, date and link checked, and a test sent to my phone.
- [ ] An unsubscribe link that works in one click.
- [ ] Every reply answered within a day.

Want your newsletter written for you?

Be More Swan's Email Marketing Assistant builds your sign-up forms, writes your welcome sequence and drafts each newsletter in your voice, using what you sell and what your other assistants have been doing.

Every email waits for your approval before it's sent.

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